

U1L10SP — Text Supplement

Danger, Necessity, and Evidence

Two scenes for close reading; the whole play remains available

How to use this supplement

You may use **anything accurate from *Julius Caesar*** in your paper. The passages below are lines worth focusing on, not limits on your evidence. Quote exact words when they are printed here. You may accurately paraphrase other events you remember from watching the play. Do not invent quotations from memory.

Passage 1: Act 2, Scene 1 — Brutus in the Orchard

Context: Before joining the conspiracy, Brutus reasons alone about Caesar. Caesar has not yet been crowned. Brutus considers what greater power might do to Caesar and what should be done now.

Brutus: It must be by his death: and for my part,
I know no personal cause to spurn at him,
But for the general. He would be crown'd:
How that might change his nature, there's the question.
It is the bright day that brings forth the adder;
And that craves wary walking. Crown him? That;
And then, I grant, we put a sting in him,
That at his will he may do danger with.
The abuse of greatness is, when it disjoins
Remorse from power: and, to speak truth of Caesar,
I have not known when his affections sway'd
More than his reason. But 'tis a common proof,
That lowliness is young ambition's ladder,
Whereto the climber-upward turns his face;
But when he once attains the upmost round,
He then unto the ladder turns his back,
Looks in the clouds, scorning the base degrees
By which he did ascend. So Caesar may.
Then, lest he may, prevent. And, since the quarrel
Will bear no colour for the thing he is,
Fashion it thus; that what he is, augmented,
Would run to these and these extremities:
And therefore think him as a serpent's egg
Which, hatch'd, would, as his kind, grow mischievous,
And kill him in the shell.

Words in context

- **spurn at:** reject or act against; **for the general:** for the public good;
- **remorse:** pity or moral restraint; **affections:** passions or desires;
- **common proof:** common experience; **base degrees:** lower steps;
- **prevent:** act beforehand; **colour:** plausible justification;
- **augmented:** increased in power; **mischievous:** harmful.

Passage 2: Act 3, Scene 2 — Antony Presses Caesar’s Record

Context: Caesar has been killed. Brutus has told Rome that Caesar was ambitious and that his death protected Roman freedom. Antony responds with examples from Caesar’s public behavior. Decide for yourself how far these examples reach.

Antony: He hath brought many captives home to Rome
Whose ransoms did the general coffers fill:
Did this in Caesar seem ambitious?
When that the poor have cried, Caesar hath wept:
Ambition should be made of sterner stuff:
Yet Brutus says he was ambitious;
And Brutus is an honourable man.
You all did see that on the Lupercal
I thrice presented him a kingly crown,
Which he did thrice refuse: was this ambition?

Words in context

- **ransoms:** payments made to free captives;
- **general coffers:** Rome’s public treasury;
- **sterner stuff:** harder or less compassionate qualities;
- **Lupercal:** a Roman festival at which Antony offered Caesar a crown;
- **thrice:** three times.

The rest of the play is available to you

You may also use accurate remembered events: Caesar’s conduct before the assassination, the conspirators’ stated motives, Brutus’s funeral speech, Antony’s persuasion of the crowd, the civil conflict that follows, or Brutus’s later judgments. These are optional reminders, not conclusions.

Use exact quotation marks only for words printed in a text you have. Other events may be paraphrased accurately. In every case, explain whether the evidence shows present fact, future possibility, or the necessity of a particular action.